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SPACE



Firefly Aerospace files for an IPO

Firefly Aerospace is taking its orbital ambitions to the public markets. The company, which notched a string of successes this year, including a historic commercial moon landing, submitted its formal declaration to regulators Friday detailing its plans to IPO.

The S-1 and Exchange ranging governance be offered disclos be dete

Firefly is \$176.9 million while it losses from operations, Firefly projected that its cash is adequate to meet its liquidity needs for at least 12 months.

The company does have a lot of debt: about \$173.6 million, including a \$136.1 million term loan with a 13.87% interest rate. The net proceeds from the IPO will be used in part to repay that outstanding loan, according to the S-1.

Firefly reportedly scored \$55.8 million in revenue as of March 31, up from just \$8.3 million for the same period in 2024. The majority of that — around \$50 million — is from “spacecraft solutions,” or its

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Blue Ghost lander missions, and just \$5 million from launch. But hardware is an expensive endeavor, and Firefly is still burning a lot of money: The cost of sales, or incurred expenses, was nearly as much as revenue — about \$53 million as of March 31, leaving just \$2.2 million in gross profit.

The company operated at a net loss of \$231.1 million for the 2024 fiscal year, up from \$135.5 million in 2023. Its net losses at the end of the first quarter were \$60.1 million.

Yet the company tells prospective investors that it sees nothing but growth ahead, and there's a handful of huge developments in the pipeline that could prove a game-changer. Firefly has a partnership with Lockheed Martin for a new lunar lander launch, and a contract with Lockheed for the debut of its first commercial space taxi.

The company is also noting that it has a backlog worth over \$1 billion in contracts, a significant boost from prior. That big boost came from three multi-launch agreements for Firefly's small Alpha rocket and an additional lunar delivery contract for its Blue Ghost lander.

The regulatory document also states Firefly intends to be a "controlled company" — essentially, that it will leverage Nasdaq rules to ensure that AE Industrial Partners, the private equity firm that bought a majority stake in Firefly in 2022, will retain significant governance control over the company even after it is listed on the public markets.

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The company intends to list on the Nasdaq Global Markets under the ticker symbol \$FLY. The news comes after a relative quiet period of space company exits. There was a slew of space companies that went public via mergers with special purpose acquisition companies in 2021 and 2022, many of which have failed to perform.

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Firefly's IPO will likely provide some much-needed liquidity to the market. Its IPO comes just one month after Voyager Space, a space company [building the private space station Starlab](#), filed its IPO paperwork last month.

Topics: [Firefly Aerospace](#) [IPO](#) [Space](#)





Aria Alamalhodaie

Reporter, Space and Defense | [X](#)

Aria Alamalhodaie covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the...

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Gary Klintworth — 7:35 AM PST · January 10, 2024

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Tech startups and high-growth companies are returning to the IPO game — despite mixed results in 2023 and a historic [public-offering drought](#). Prime contenders in the coming months include healthcare payments company Waystar, with

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media reports suggesting cybersecurity startup [Rubrik](#) and micromobility firm [Lime](#) are also considering IPOs. And with artificial intelligence startups continuing to make waves in venture rounds, it wouldn't be surprising to see several companies IPO further down the road.

Yet given bankers' and investors' ongoing focus on clear pathways to profitability and positive cash flows, venture-backed companies looking to tap public markets must concentrate on their business fundamentals and execution while clearly understanding the path to future growth.

In what follows, we'll discuss why some of today's tech startups are struggling to raise capital and how to improve your chances.

Why

It's an e-commerce company. Budget cuts. Wages and a high cost of capital. They can't either u

valuations come back so they can raise another venture round as a bridge to an IPO. However, many have already done cuts or layoffs, and the concern is whether they have enough runway to wait it out.

Post-2021, startups looking to IPO — typically late-stage, venture-backed companies that need significant funding to keep growing — might have turned to private capital or debt financing instead of going public. But in today's economic climate, those fundraising sources are often less available or may be less attractive. For instance, [VC funding has slowed](#) and is increasingly oriented toward

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early-stage startups, while high interest rates make raising capital through debt financing expensive.

Internal forces also drive IPO interest despite the [mixed reception](#) for prominent recent listings like Instacart and Klaviyo. Some early-stage startup investors are seeking exits. At the same time, employees who may have been with a company since its early days want to flex their stock options. Such factors, of course, are always in play for fast-

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What's more, the IPO process can open new doors: For instance, the run-up to the listing and the IPO day serve as an opportunity for media coverage and a marketing event to draw in new customers and investors. IPOs also play a role in mergers and acquisitions, creating a stock currency companies can use to fuel inorganic growth through all-stock deals to acquire rivals or complementary

businesses. Before going effective, the IPO process involves establishing a pricing range that can create dual-track interest for private equity or strategic investors who may also consider acquiring startups that could bolster their own business or portfolio.

According to Renaissance Capital, these factors contribute to the gradual thawing of the IPO market after 2022's historic lows: There were 82 U.S. IPOs in the first three quarters of 2023, a 28% increase compared to the same period in 2022. The SPAC merger bust is mainly behind us, and recent IPO success stories include the 2023 debuts of biotech startups *Structure* and *Genlux*, whose post-listing stock prices rose 100% and 100%, respectively.

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These days, investors are laser-focused on the path to profits and cash flows. It's not enough to chart revenue growth, promise international expansion, or grow in tertiary markets.

Consequently, many bankers who underwrite IPOs are now looking for metrics that show positive traction for three quarters *before* the IPO event, such as acquiring larger customers and moving up the market, customer retention, and diversification of industry and customer base. Some also want companies to clearly demonstrate they can be cash-flow positive within a short period *after* becoming a public company.

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Ensure that the suitable systems, processes, and people are in place ahead of the IPO

You need quality data to forecast the key metrics investors demand from a public company. That can be a challenge for fast-growing startups, which tend to have disparate systems that may not effectively “speak” to each other — and may not be able to stand up to post-IPO volume. Limit the number of financial systems you use, and ensure they have good APIs (application programming interfaces) to help smooth transitions as you consolidate.

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Provide to be a public company, from drafting mock earnings releases and 10-Q filings to preparing for the rigor of that first external audit. For example, startups need to start reliably “closing the books” quarterly — not just for accounting reasons, but to ensure they’ve got an accurate snapshot of the business.

You can’t predict your future stock price — but you can control performance

Going public can sometimes force business leaders into a short-term mentality amid investor

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pressure to show growth each quarter. Such thinking can prioritize quick wins over the more strategic, long-term investments needed to spur sustained growth.

Remember, most public technology companies don't find success or create substantial value until the later stages. The elements that can fuel that trajectory include diversification, inorganic growth through M&A, and international expansion. Get the correct elements in place for growth *before* your IPO, and your startup can make steady progress as a public company, hitting milestones along the path to long-term success.

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Gary K
Contributor

Gary Klintworth is a seasoned financial executive with 25+ years of experience in industry, accounting, leadership...

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Funding Circle, a P2P SME lending platform, steps towards an IPO

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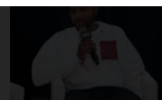
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possible future IPO, Funding Circle says that should it proceed with floating on the stock market it would be looking to raise around £300 million (~\$387M). According to the document the business is being valued at up to £1.65BN (~\$2.1BN).

Heartland A/S, the private holding company of Danish billionaire businessman, Anders Holch Povlsen, has agreed, as part of the potential IPO Offer, to purchase 10% of the issued ordinary share capital at a range of valuations (but Funding Circle notes this commitment falls away if the equity valuation prior to the issue of new Shares pursuant to the Offer exceeds £1.65BN).

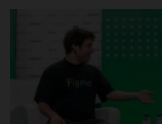


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STARTUPS



Figma's IPO success is 'a little
bit of a meme stock,' says
Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

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- 18 hours ago

Funding Circle has raised more than \$373M to date since being founded back in 2010. The founders had the idea to help small businesses obtain loans after the retrenching of traditional financing sources after the 2008 financial crash.

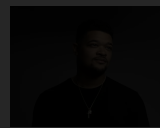
The global lending platform now connects investors in the U.K., U.S., Germany and the Netherlands with small businesses wanting to borrow money for growth. More than 80,000 retail investors, banks, asset management companies, insurance companies, government-backed entities and funds have lent more than £5BN to over 50,000 businesses globally since the platform's launch in 2010.

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businesses and investors around the world. I am very proud of the team and culture we have created at Funding Circle, both of which have been integral to our success to date”.

STARTUPS



Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the ‘agent-native economy’

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Funding Circle exited the property loans business in 2016, tightening its focus on small business financing.

According to the registration document, repeat business is growing, with approximately 40% of Funding Circle's revenue generated from existing customers in 2017 (again excluding property loans).

It also says that attractive unit economics are driving expanded margins, with the margin per loan in 2017 rising from approximately 20% for the first loan, to ~57% for repeat loans in the UK. And it adds that the path to superior margins is driven by operational leverage.

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“It is a prime example of a new breed of financial services companies, who by making their products more transparent and more convenient, have democratised access to valuable services and increased economic activity.

Rimer added: “Funding Circle has a broad impact on the growing businesses it funds, the employees they hire, the communities they operate, their customers and the countries they operate in. This is an important milestone that will allow the company to support tens of thousands of additional small

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businesses: something everyone should celebrate.”

Index is Funding Circle’s largest shareholder and has been a backer of the business since its Series A funding round in 2011 — when it became the 2010 founded UK startup’s first institutional investor. It’s just posted a [blog post](#) to coincide with Funding Circle’s announcement — taking an inside look at the company mission and ethos.

Index also has several other fintech investments in its portfolio, including the likes of Adyen, iZettle, Revolut and Robinhood. Though the VC firm did not take an investment in UK-based payday loans firm

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Natasha was a senior reporter for TechCrunch, from September 2012 to April 2025, based in Europe. She joine...

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